Abhishek Lamba

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Abhishek Lamba is a game designer, writer, performer, and educator. They co-created SHASN:AZADI, a board game about freedom struggles, which went on to become the first board game ever to win a social impact award at Games For Change. They have written, designed, and performed in immersive experiences like She Moves Tech, Blood Moon Over Bengaluru, and Half-Life Curse. They are also the creator of Artcade Night, a one of its kind event where they gamify art exhibits. Along with that, they are a co-founder of One Last Rule Club: a community of designers and artists in Bombay. They are proudly non-binary.

MEMESYS STUDIOS

CO-CREATOR OF SHASN: AZADI

- **I co-created SHASN: AZADI, a political strategy board game** where players play as revolutionaries, trying to free their country from the grips of tyrannical imperial powers.
- Launching on **Kickstarter** in 2021, **the game raised over 200,000$** from backers across the world.
- Ideating this project from scratch, designing the game, and successfully funding it via Kickstarter, from the first prototype to a fully manufactured, award-winning, market-ready game, **I have led this project from end to end.**
- This included: **leading teams of game designers, graphic designers, concept artists and marketing executives for a period of over 2 years.**
- **I also served as a writer and head editor for the project.** Being a game about real-life freedom struggles, **I worked with academics, journalists, and writers across the world** - from **Egypt, Hong Kong, USA, and India.**
- In 2023 SHASN: AZADI became the first board game ever to **win at the prestigious Games For Change Awards** in New York, being recognized for its social impact.
- In 2022, the trailer for SHASN: AZADI, directed by Anand Gandhi, won the Writing for Advertising award at the D & AD Awards.
- Already touted as the **'blueprint for semi-cooperative games'** (Brian Winters, Board Game Quest)

AWARDS

Games For Change
Social Impact Award — **2023**

D & AD Awards
Writing for Advertising — **2022**

EDUCATION

Jai Hind College: Bachelor of Arts
English Literature — **2017**

Young India Fellowship
Diploma in Liberal Arts — **2018**

SOMAIYA COLLEGE OF DESIGN + ISDI

PROFESSOR OF GAME DESIGN

NOV 2023 - PRESENT

- I have **delivered four complete courses of game design** at the Somaiya College of Design and the Indian School of Design and Innovation in Mumbai.
- **Beginning with the fundamentals, going all the way to the essentials of game theory**, my course provides a comprehensive look into the world of game design.
- With **my entire pedagogy being gamified,** the students discover a unique and fun way of learning.
- Foregoing the didactic approach to pedagogy, **I created games for each of my classes** such that students can learn by the practical experience that games can offer.
- These games cover topics related to the **fundamentals of game design, game theory, the role of games in evolutionary biology, crafting one's authorship, identity, and building community.**
- My course gives students the tools and the platform to **discover their authorial voice and create their very first board games.**
- Across 4 different courses and two years, my classes have led to **the creation of more than 10 board games.**

GOVANDI ARTS FESTIVAL

ARTIST IN RESIDENCE

JUL 2024 - DEC 2024

- As an **Artist in Residence** with the Govandi Arts Festival, I received a grant to work within the **low-income housing community** of Natwar Parekh Colony, where the life expectancy is only 39 years.
- As part of my residency, I taught a class of four 13 year old girls, teaching them game design.
- My students and I co-authored a game called **Mohalla** together.
- For the game, we took inspiration from Natwar Parekh Colony and **low-income housing communities** around the world,
- In this semi cooperative game, players take on the role of a community leader in their Mohalla. (neighborhood)
- **Players compete to be the most successful leader by creating new projects for their building, but must also collaborate with other leaders to ensure the collective survival of their community by raising its life expectancy.** Mohalla is a game about finding the balance between "mine" and "ours."
- The game is fully developed and was even exhibited at the **Kochi Bienalle** in 2026.
- With monthly visits, my relationship with my students has now gone beyond the scope of this festival.

IMMERSE

WRITER, DESIGNER, ACTOR

FEB 2025 - PRESENT

- With Immerse, I have combined my expertise in game design and writing to create and perform in a variety of **Immersive Experiences**.
- I worked as a writer on Immersive Experiences like **Blood Moon Over Bengaluru, Three Wise Fools, She Moves Tech, and Half-Life Curse.**
- She Moves Tech is a science fiction immersive experience set in the near future, exploring the potential consequences of **gender biases in AI.**
- Blood Moon Over Bengaluru is a **queer horror mystery**, where the audience must work together to help lift a curse on a queer woman experiencing erasure from the society around her.
- These productions have had shows in **Delhi, Goa, Bombay, and Bangalore**. Most recently, Blood Moon Over Bengaluru attracted more than 400 people across 8 shows in Bengaluru.

ARTCADE

GAME DESIGN, ART

AUG 2024 - PRESENT

- Bringing together my love for art and game design, I created Artcade Night, a show that **uses games to take the audience on an immersive and interactive journey across an art exhibit's narrative and historical contexts.**
- Exploring **the intersection of art and play**, Artcade Night has evolved into a wonderful tool that can make art accessible and enjoyable for everyone.
- Artcade Night has sold out shows in reputed art galleries across Mumbai and Bengaluru, including **Art+Charlie, Chemould CoLab, Museum of Art and Photography,** and **CSMVS**, Bombay's oldest art gallery.
- **Bridging the gap between galleries, museums, and common people,** Artcade Night is proof of the role that gamification can play in spreading art literacy.

SOCIAL WORK

ONGOING

- **Over the past decade**, I have **designed and conducted numerous curriculums** with The Gender Lab, Khula Aasmaan, and Philarthropy **in low-income housing areas and resource poor schools.**
- Recently, along with Krupa Foundation, I have also created **a gamified addiction toolkit**, designed to help prevent relapse.

ONE LAST RULE CLUB

ONGOING

- I am a **co-founder of One Last Rule Club**, a **Bombay based community** to meet-up, play games & help people build wonderful things!
- With monthly meet-ups since 2023, One Last Rule Club has attracted many members, many of whom are **artists, designers, and creators.**